NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥Q

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦8

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 7NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♠10

Board: 4
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♣J

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦Q

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ K 5 ♥ A 6 4 ♦ 9 6 2 ♣ A K Q 6 3	
♠ Q 10 4 ♥ K 10 5 2 ♦ A J 7 3 ♣ J 5	N W E S	♠ J 9 ♥ Q J 9 7 3 ♦ Q 8 4 ♣ 10 7 4
	♠ A 8 7 6 3 2 ♥ 8 ♦ K 10 5 ♣ 9 8 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♥
Pass	2♠	Pass	3♠
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♥Q

You have an invitational strength hand with a 6-card Major suit. It's a no-brainer; you transfer with a 2♥ bid. Partner says 2♠;

You have an invitational strength hand with a 6-card Major suit. It's a no-brainer; you transfer with a 2♥ bid. Partner says 2♠;

Repeat: You have an **invitational** strength hand with a **6-card** Major suit. So you invite with 3♠s. Partner accepts with 4♠.

The contract would be 4♠ played by South.

North plays 4♠. East leads the ♥Q. Of course you take the ♥A.

Loser List: ♠ = 1/2/3 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 4/5/6

Missing 5 ♠s, the most likely split is 3-2, (68% of the time). You win the ♥A then play ♠K and ♠A, both defenders following to both leads but the ♠Q is still out there.

Do you play ♠s again or not?

Usually it is a good idea to leave a master trump un-pulled and go about your business winning tricks in other suits. The idea is to force them to ruff without using any more of your trumps. But that is only "usually". Here your big source of winners is going to be the ♣ suit - and there are zero outside entries to it. Suppose you do not force out the ♠Q, but start playing ♣ winners. A defender might ruff the third ♣ and you would be doomed.

So play one more ♠ and they are doomed.

Master trump outstanding: To pull or not to pull, that is the question.

Almost always the answer is "not to pull".

The big exception is when you have a running suit in one hand but with no outside entries to it. A hand exactly like this one.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 10 7 5 ♥ 6 3 ♦ Q J 10 9 ♣ J 5 4 2	
♠ A J 3 ♥ K Q 9 7 4 ♦ 7 6 4 2 ♣ 10	N W E S	♠ K Q ♥ A J 10 ♦ A K 5 3 ♣ A 8 7 3
	♠ 9 8 6 4 2 ♥ 8 5 2 ♦ 8 ♣ K Q 9 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2NT	Pass
3♦	Pass	4♥	Pass
4NT[1]	Pass	5♠[2]	Pass
6♥			
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 3 aces

6♥ by East
Lead: ♦8

You know you may be in slam territory, but first you need to establish trumps. So you bid 3♦ as a transfer and almost faint when partner jumps to 4♥, showing a super-accept. Now

You know you may be in slam territory, but first you need to establish trumps. So you bid 3♦ as a transfer and almost faint when partner jumps to 4♥, showing a super-accept. Now

Check for Aces with Blackwood, partner replies 5♠. What next?

You know you may be in slam territory, but first you need to establish trumps. So you bid 3♦ as a transfer and almost faint when partner jumps to 4♥, showing a super-accept. Now

Check for Aces with Blackwood, partner replies 5♠. What next?

Partner shows three Aces. You can't consider a Grand Slam, so bid 6♥.

The contract would be 6♥ played by West.

East plays 6♥. South leads the ♦8, on which North plays the ♦9. You win the ♦K.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2

If you look just at the West and East hands you would think this was a pretty easy slam to make. Pull trumps and play three rounds of ♦s, and as long as the ♦s split 3-2 you make twelve tricks. But when you consider the ♦8 opening lead you realize that it won't happen. The missing ♦s are Q J 10 9 and 8. The ONLY combination from which South would lead the ♦8 is when he has a singleton. So the ♦s won't be splitting and you need a different plan.

You need to get a ♦ discard somewhere, and dummy's third ♠ will take care of one of **YOUR** ♦ losers. But then to establish **YOUR** hand you are going to have to ruff all 3 ♣ losers.

Play the ♣A and ruff a ♣. Enter your hand with the ♥10 and ruff another ♣ high. Back to your hand with the ♥J and ruff another ♣ high. Dummy is out of trumps but there is still one more in a defender's hand. So come to your hand with the ♠Q and pull the last trump, discarding a ♦ from dummy.

With all the trumps pulled cash dummy's 2 ♠s and your ♦A, then give up a ♦ at the last trick.

This isn't strictly a dummy-reversal since you actually used your own hand to pull trumps and dummy's trumps for ruffing.

However it's a "role reversal", you pulled trumps with the short-trump hand and took three ruffs in the long-trump hand.

But call it whatever you like, that's the way to make this Deal.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ A 6 ♥ A 6 5 ♦ K 7 6 2 ♣ K Q 10 3	
♠ 10 9 8 5 2 ♥ 9 7 2 ♦ 8 3 ♣ 8 6 5	N W E S	♠ K 4 3 ♥ 8 4 3 ♦ J 10 9 4 ♣ 9 7 2
	♠ Q J 7 ♥ K Q J 10 ♦ A Q 5 ♣ A J 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2NT
Pass	4♣	Pass	4♠
Pass	7NT		
All Pass			

7NT by South
Lead: ♠10

You have 16 points and partner has 20-21. If you bid 7NT right now just because it is something you always wanted to do, then I don't blame you. But if you're cautious you'll use Gerber 4♣. Partner bids 4♠;

You have 16 points and partner has 20-21. If you bid 7NT right now just because it is something you always wanted to do, then I don't blame you. But if you're cautious you'll use Gerber 4♣. Partner bids 4♠;

OK, you have all the Aces. You are missing 4 points at most, possibly a King and a Jack, or two Queens. You could continue with Gerber and find out about the Kings, or you could pick between 6NT and 7NT right now. You go for the gusto with 7NT!

The contract would be 7NT played by North.

South plays 7NT. West leads the ♠10. Do you play the ♠A or a low card?.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 4 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 4 :: Total = 12

If West has led from ♠ K 10 9 x, then all you have to do to make this contract is play a low card from dummy. But a decent defender would not make such a risky lead against a 7NT contract, so it is probable that East has the ♠K. You rise with the ♠A.

You hope the ♦s will split 3-3, but if they don't you still have the possibility of squeezing East if he holds 4 ♦s along with the ♠K you have assigned to him.

If it comes to a squeeze it is important to take your tricks in the correct order. First take 4 ♣ tricks, discarding the ♠J from your hand. You note that East discards a small ♠ on the fourth ♣.

Next take 4 ♥ winners, discarding dummy's useless ♠6 and keeping all 4 ♦s. On the fourth ♥ East must come down to a 4-card holding; he must either throw his ♠K, (you are happy) or he can throw one of his ♦s, (you are happy).

This was an automatic squeeze.

That means you didn't have to do anything special, just play your winners in the right order and keep your eyes open to see if the ♠K gets discarded.

Of course if the ♦s were breaking 3-3 all the time you haven't lost anything by playing for the squeeze.

Board 4
East Deals
Both Vul

	♠ Q 7 ♥ 9 5 4 ♦ 10 9 5 2 ♣ J 10 9 7	
♠ A 9 8 6 2 ♥ K J 10 7 2 ♦ 6 ♣ 4 2		♠ K 5 ♥ Q 8 6 ♦ A Q 7 3 ♣ K Q 8 6
	♠ J 10 4 3 ♥ A 3 ♦ K J 8 4 ♣ A 5 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♥	Pass	2♠	Pass
3♥	Pass	4♥	
All Pass			

4♥ by West
Lead: ♣J

Partner's bid is a transfer asking you to bid 2♠, so you do. Partner now bids 3♥;

Partner's bid is a transfer asking you to bid 2♠, so you do. Partner now bids 3♥;

Partner is showing 5-5 in the Majors, with at least invitational strength. It's a close thing, but you decide to accept the invitation and bid 4♥.

The contract would be 4♥ played by East.

West plays 4♥. North leads the ♣J. You play the ♣Q. South wins with the ♣A and plays the ♥A then the ♥3.

Loser List: ♠ = 1/2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 3/4

South trump play was good defense; it has prevented you from ruffing 2 ♠s in dummy. Even so your best plan will be to establish the ♠ suit.

So you next play ♠K, ♠A, then ruff a ♠ with dummy's ♥Q. North does not follow to the third ♠.

Next play ♦A and get to your hand by ruffing a ♦. Pull the last trump, then give up a ♠ to South. Win his return, (by ruffing if necessary) and take your established ♠ winner and dummy's ♣K.

Suppose you had considered taking the ♦ finesse. It would have done you no good at all.

If it worked, all you could do would be to discard your fifth ♠; but that was the ♠ that turned out to be a winner!

It was the fourth ♠ that was a loser, and you couldn't get rid of that one.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ K 5 ♥ A 9 4 3 ♦ A 6 4 ♣ A 9 8 2	
♠ Q 8 3 2 ♥ K Q 10 ♦ 10 8 3 ♣ Q 7 5	N W E S	♠ J 10 7 ♥ J 5 ♦ Q J 9 2 ♣ J 10 4 3
	♠ A 9 6 4 ♥ 8 7 6 2 ♦ K 7 5 ♣ K 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♣
Pass	2♥	Pass	4♥
All Pass			

4♥ by North
Lead: ♦Q

With 10 points and two 4-card Majors you bid 2♣ Stayman. Partner says 2♥;

With 10 points and two 4-card Majors you bid 2♣ Stayman. Partner says 2♥;

Now you add a point for your doubleton, get to 11 points, and bid 4♥.

The contract would be 4♥ played by South.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♦Q. Win the ♦Q in either hand. Lets say you win with your ♦A.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 2* : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 3*

*Don't get overconfident with this loser list. It assumes that trumps break 3-2, (if they don't you cannot make it), and also assumes you will be able to cross-ruff 4 small black cards.

Cross-ruffing those 4 losers could be a problem. You can't afford to get over-ruffed so it would be nice if you could pull some trumps before you start the cross-ruff. But you must make sure that only two rounds of trumps get pulled, otherwise you won't have the trumps for the cross-ruff.

It is actually simple to make sure exactly two rounds of trumps are drawn. At trick 2 just duck a ♥ in each hand. An opponent will win this, but you can take the next trick, (probably a ♦), and then pull a second round of trumps with your ♥A. Then leave the trumps alone and play your two black A K's, then start cross-ruffing with your 4 tiny trumps. The defender with the master trump can over-ruff when he can, and can even cash a ♦. But that's all he can do so you will make your game.

Suppose you had played first the ♥A, then a small ♥.

West would have won the second one, and if he had then continued ♦s you would have made the contract.

But if he was a good enough defender to pull a THIRD round of trumps, getting 2 for the price of 1 value, you would have been defeated.